

beings who are our clients to the best of our ability; being prudent stewards of the assets they have entrusted to us; treating them as we would like the stewards of our own assets to treat us; and serving them with candor, with empathy, with fair dealing, and with integrity.^{[18](#)}

In my time as head of Vanguard, none of these standards and values was ever written down in a manual. Rather, I proposed a single overarching but simple rule: “Do what’s right. If you’re not sure, ask your boss.” Why so? Because as I’ve said a thousand times: “Good ethics *is* good business.” A new thought? Hardly. In the *Odyssey*, Homer reminds us,

*Take it to the heart, and pass the word along:
Fair dealing brings more profit in the end.*

I’ve read untold numbers of books and articles about business management and corporate strategy, but I’ve never seen the phrase *human beings* as representing the key to business leadership. But when I think of both our clients and crew, that phrase has been the key to everything we’ve accomplished.

Rule 4: Talk the Talk. Repeat the Values Endlessly.

If building a great workforce demands leadership, and if leadership requires virtue—and I have no doubt that the best leadership does require virtue—then a leader can be defined as *a person who initiates and directs an endeavor in the principled pursuit of a project of consequence*. To lead at all levels—from chief executives to senior managers to project directors, even to those souls responsible for the most mundane of tasks—requires inspiring and persuading other human beings to work together on a journey toward a worthwhile destination.

Building a great organization demands finding the right words to communicate the best ideas and the highest ideals, words that convey purpose and passion and vision. In the effort to do so, we